To make matters worse, the British had failed to come to the aid of their Persian allies, so leaving the Persians to face the Russians alone. Following a further series of catastrophic Persian defeats in the Russo-Persian War of 1826–7, the Persians lost all that was left of their Caucasian empire, including all the passes controlling the road to Azerbaijan.[50]

If Russia had not also been fighting the Ottomans, the surrender terms might have been harsher still. But Russia was simultaneously inflicting defeats on the Turks so damaging that the Duke of Wellington believed they marked a 'death blow to the independence of the Ottoman Porte and the forerunner of the extinction of its power'.[51] By the end of the 1820s it seemed only a matter of time before the Russians seized both Teheran and Constantinople, turning Persia and Turkey into vast Tsarist protectorates. In Chechnya and Daghestan, the Russians were conducting a series of genocidal punitive expeditions during which they sacked villages, killed the women and children, cut down the forests and destroyed the crops.[52] Further south still, in Jerusalem, the British Consul was reporting a build-up of 'Russian agents' preparing for a 'Russian conquest of the Holy Lands'. Russia's stated intention to recreate the old Byzantine Empire on the ruins of that of the Ottomans made such schemes appear perfectly plausible, at least to the foreign-policy hawks.[53]

This rapid succession of Russian victories, combined with reports of Russian brutality in the lands they controlled, came as a severe shock to the politicians in London, who since the demise of Napoleon had come to see the security of British India as vital to Britain's status as a world power. When in 1823 the Himalayan explorer William Moorcroft managed to intercept a letter from the Russian Foreign Minister, Count Nesselrode, to Ranjit Singh, it seemed to confirm all the hawks' worst fears. These fears, and the political paranoia they generated, triggered a wave of Russophobia in the British and British Indian press where Russia increasingly came to be depicted as a barbaric and despotic menace to liberty and civilisation.

This was given momentum by the publication of Colonel De Lacy Evans's overwrought polemic *On the Practicability of an Invasion of British India*. The book sketched out a scenario whereby 60,000 Russian troops could march across the Hindu Kush, take Herat, then appear at the base of the Khyber Pass and sweep all before them. In reality, at this period this was almost as fantastical a scheme as Shah Shuja's plan to invade Kabul via 'Thibet', and the Russian threat it presented was hugely overplayed: there